Katie & Nathaniel

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Early Childhood

The Great Afternoon

Cartoons Are for Life: The Secret Password & The Afternoon Sanctuary

Date: 1994-05-18 at 15:30 America/New_York

3:30 PM — The Secret Password

Three polite, measured knocks sounded against the painted wood of my closed bedroom door just as the red digital clock on the cable converter box ticked to `3:29`.

“Cartoons are for life,” came Katie’s voice through the wood, hushed and completely serious.

The secret password was given. Immediately, I scrambled up off the dark low-pile carpet of my deep-blue bedroom and swung the door open to admit my twin sister just in time for our favorite afternoon block of cartoons. Having just turned nine years old back on April eighth, neither of us cared what the other kids on our street in Virginia Beach were doing after the school bus dropped us off. School was six straight hours of scraping desks, unpredictable bells, and teachers who tried to seat fraternal twins on opposite sides of the hallway just because I was a boy and Katie was a girl. To the teachers at school and the adults in our extended family, I was Nathaniel, though Dad and Katie half the time just called me Nate; behind this door, I was simply the other half of Katie’s perimeter.

Katie slipped inside, her long, straight platinum-blonde hair swinging past her shoulders as she pulled the door shut behind her until the latch clicked. We didn’t need to explain to anyone else why we had a password for a room ten feet away from her own bedroom down the hall. Out in the rest of the house, the afternoon air was already heavy—Mom had locked her bedroom door at two o’clock with another headache and a glass from the kitchen cabinet, and Dad wouldn’t be home from work until five-thirty to start dinner. Behind my closed door, however, the rules belonged entirely to the two of us.

I rushed back across the carpet and pressed the power button on the front of the television and the cable converter box just as the Majestic Studios castle logo and the afternoon cartoon block bumper flashed across the curved glass tube.

The opening brass fanfare of the *Galactic Samurai Geckos* theme song burst out of the small speaker grille, and instantly, both of us got completely carried away. Katie grabbed both of my hands, and for the next sixty seconds we bounced on the balls of our feet in the middle of the carpet, belting out every single word of the intro theme in unison while the animated title cards rolled across the screen.

Then, just as quickly, the final drumbeat of the opening theme faded out, the episode title card appeared, and the two of us were brought gently back to earth.

Without letting go of my hand, Katie dropped down onto the carpet right beside me, leaning her shoulder firmly against mine. I adjusted the volume knob down two notches so the dialogue wouldn’t echo into the hallway, rested my back against the side of my bed frame, and let my sister’s weight anchor me in place while the afternoon cartoons glowed across the quiet room.

Summer Camp at Virginia Dominion University

The Parallel Pair: Dominion Mall & The VDU Fieldhouse

Date: 1994-07-12 at 08:45 America/New_York

8:45 AM — Two Pairs on Dominion Mall

“All right, Youth Division, let’s buddy up in two lines for the walk across Dominion Mall!” Counselor Brad announced over the splash of the circular concrete plaza fountain, tapping his wooden clipboard with a grin.

Standing on the wide, sun-bleached concrete plaza of Virginia Dominion University in Norfolk at eight-forty-five in the morning, wearing matching royal-blue VDU Summer Camp t-shirts over our shorts, Katie immediately tightened her fingers around my right wrist. When our dad, David Prairie, had signed the two of us up for this two-week, all-day camp block—running from nine o’clock in the morning until four o’clock in the afternoon—he had wanted to keep us safely out of the house in July while he was at work. Katie and I had our own rule for surviving six hours a day around fifteen noisy, unfamiliar kids: we were not letting go of each other.

Two paces ahead of us in the Youth Division line, I noticed we weren’t the only brother and sister operating on that exact protocol.

A nine-year-old boy with reddish-blond hair and wire-rimmed glasses—whose name tag read *Michael*—and his seven-year-old sister *Rachel*, who had dark shoulder-length hair and glasses of her own, were standing hip-to-hip with their fingers laced together in a white-knuckled grip while their fourteen-year-old sister adjusted her backpack beside them before heading over to the Senior Division group. Just like Katie and me, Michael and Rachel didn’t care about the cartoons or baseball cards the other campers were shouting about; they were holding onto each other like their lives depended on it.

Naturally, the two college-age counselors running our Youth Division—Counselor Brad and Counselor Kelly—looked at the four of us and reached the exact wrong conclusion.

“Look at this—we’ve got two brothers and two sisters right next to each other!” Brad called out brightly. “Let’s mix it up today so the boys can hang out with the boys and the girls can hang out with the girls! Michael, step right back here and pair up with Nathaniel! And Rachel, you team up with Katie!”

Before I could protest, Brad guided me a step forward beside Michael, while Kelly gently steered Katie two steps back beside Rachel.

For four seconds, the counselors’ geometry held.

I looked sideways at Michael through the thick Tidewater humidity. Michael looked sideways at me behind his wire-rimmed glasses. Neither of us had anything against the other—in fact, I could tell in half a heartbeat that his brain hated the sudden change in the line just as much as mine did. Behind us, Katie wasn’t saying a word to Rachel, and Rachel wasn’t saying a word to Katie; both of our sisters were staring straight at the backs of our blue camp shirts with their shoulders stiff and their jaws locked tight.

Michael and I didn’t need to say a single word out loud. As soon as Counselor Brad turned his back and held his clipboard up in the air to lead the group across the light-gray concrete squares of Dominion Mall, Michael gave me a tiny, solemn nod, and I nodded right back.

I stepped half a pace to my left. Michael stepped half a pace to his right. In the exact same motion, Katie slipped forward to grab my hand again, and Rachel stepped right back into place on Michael's left flank.

By the time our sneakers clicked across the second concrete expansion joint past the circular fountain toward the precast-concrete and blue-glass facade of the University Library, the boy-and-girl experiment was completely over. It was brother and sister on the left, and twin brother and twin sister on the right.

9:30 AM — Terminal 4 and Terminal 5

At nine-thirty, the counselors ushered us out of the ninety-degree heat into the sixty-eight-degree air conditioning of the university computer lab.

Thirty beige desktop towers running *Quantum OS* and curved CRT monitors lined the walls, their cooling fans humming in a low, steady chord behind rows of mechanical *KeyMech* keyboards. I loved computers almost as much as I loved our afternoon cartoons, and Katie loved sitting beside me while we took turns with the mouse and keyboard.

Counselor Brad, however, still hadn't given up on his clipboard chart.

"Okay, campers, listen up!" Brad called out from the front desk, holding up a plastic tray of 3.5-inch floppy disks. "Boys on the left wall row—we've got *Wagon Train West* and *Where on the Map Is Scarlet Devereaux?* loaded up! Girls on the right wall row for *Digit Chompers* and *PixelPaint Junior*!"

Brad pointed Michael to Terminal 4 and guided me into the rolling plastic chair right next to him at Terminal 5. Across the blue carpet, Counselor Kelly led Rachel and Katie to Terminals 19 and 20 against the opposite wall.

The moment Katie's hand left my wrist, the hum of the computer lab stopped feeling calming and started feeling like a trap. Down the row to our left, a boy in a basketball cap was pounding his mechanical spacebar with both thumbs and yelling at the screen as his wagon sank in a river. I didn't touch my keyboard at Terminal 5. Instead, I twisted halfway around in my plastic chair and looked straight across the center aisle.

At Terminal 20, Katie was sitting completely motionless in front of the flashing five-by-five number grid of *Digit Chompers*, twisting the hem of her royal-blue camp shirt around her fingers while looking back across the carpet at me. Right beside her at Terminal 19, Rachel Ragsdale had pulled both hands off her desk and tucked her knuckles tightly against her chest.

Next to me at Terminal 4, Michael pushed his chair back six inches and looked at his sister. At the exact same moment, I tapped the open corner of my desk at Terminal 5 and motioned to Katie.

While Brad was kneeling beside the dot-matrix printer at the front of the room, Katie and Rachel slid off their chairs in perfect synchronization and walked three quiet steps side by side across the carpet.

Rachel squeezed onto the right half of Michael's seat at Terminal 4, and Katie pulled the empty rolling chair from the end of the row right up against my right side at Terminal 5, her long platinum-blonde hair brushing my sleeve as she exhaled a long, quiet breath of relief.

"Hey, girls, your computers are still running over on the right wall—" Counselor Kelly started, walking down the aisle before stopping short as she took in the two identical brother-and-sister teams sitting shoulder-to-shoulder at Terminals 4 and 5.

"She's playing with me," Michael told her quietly from Terminal 4, his left hand resting on the arrow keys while Rachel's right thumb hovered over the spacebar for *Digit Chompers*. "I steer the square, and Rachel chomps the multiples. That's how we play."

I rested my left hand on the keyboard of Terminal 5 and placed Katie's hand over the beige two-button mouse for *Wagon Train West*.

"Katie's my twin," I said, looking up at Kelly with quiet, unshakable certainty. "We always play together."

Kelly looked from Michael and Rachel to Katie and me. Neither pair was making noise, neither pair was arguing, and the panicked stiffness had vanished from all four of us the second the sisters were back beside their brothers. Slowly, Kelly smiled, pulled an extra chair over for Rachel so both pairs had two seats pushed flush together, and jotted a quick note on her clipboard.

"Okay," Kelly said gently. "Michael and Rachel on Terminal 4, Nathaniel and Katie on Terminal 5."

For the next hour and a half, Katie and I guided our pixel wagon all the way across the western rivers without losing a single ox—trading turns with the mouse while Michael and Rachel cleared screen after screen of *Digit Chompers* two feet to our left.

1:30 PM — Pair 1 and Pair 2 at the Fieldhouse Pool

After eating our grilled cheese sandwiches side by side in the Monarch Commons dining hall at noon—just a few seats down from where Michael and Rachel's fourteen-year-old sister Jessica used her written lunch exception on the camp roster to sit with them and quiz them on campus landmarks—our group walked down Hampton Boulevard to the VDU Fieldhouse.

The Fieldhouse was a massive brick athletic building where the Lady Admirals played women's basketball during the school year while the men's team played downtown under the concrete dome of the Norfolk Prism. Down the rubber-floored hallway, through the double doors of the Fieldhouse Natatorium, the indoor swimming pool echoed with splashing water and bouncing whistles.

As soon as I stepped out of the boys' locker room in my swim trunks, Katie stepped out of the girls' locker room door in her navy one-piece swimsuit, walked straight across the wet white tile, and grabbed my hand with both of hers. Right next to us on the bench, Rachel Ragsdale did the exact same thing with Michael.

Up on the deck beside the white plastic Buddy Board, Counselor Brad held up his thick black grease pencil and tried the gender split one last time.

“Every fifteen minutes when the lifeguard blows the long whistle and yells *Buddy Check*, you and your buddy have to find each other in the shallow end, grab hands, and hold them up in the air!” Brad called out over the echoing cavern. “Michael and Nathaniel, you guys are Pair Four! Rachel and Katie, you two are Pair Nine!”

Katie squeezed my fingers tightly as thirty kids splashed into the pool at once. I didn’t let go of her hand, and four feet to my left, Michael didn’t let go of Rachel’s. Together, both pairs walked down the wide fiberglass steps into the warm, three-foot shallow end along the side wall.

Two minutes later, the head lifeguard on the high white chair raised his silver whistle to his lips.

TWEEEEET!

“BUDDY CHECK!” the lifeguard shouted through his red megaphone. “Find your buddy and hands in the air!”

Out in the middle of the shallow end, kids who had been chasing each other in *Admirals and Anchors* pool tag splashed around in circles trying to remember who their assigned partner was.

Along the shallow wall, Katie’s left hand was already laced tightly through my right hand, and Rachel’s right hand was already laced tightly through Michael’s left. Before the whistle had even stopped echoing off the steel roof trusses of the Fieldhouse, all four of us raised our joined hands straight into the air above the water.

Up on the deck, Counselor Brad stared at our two pairs of raised brother-and-sister hands, looked at Counselor Kelly laughing softly behind her clipboard, and finally surrendered. Wiping his rag across the grease pencil on the white plastic board, Brad wrote two new permanent assignments at the very top of the list:

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PAIR 1: MICHAEL + RACHEL PAIR 2: NATHANIEL + KATIE
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Katie looked at me as we lowered our arms back into the warm water, a bright, triumphant smile breaking across her face, and across the lane Michael and Rachel shared the exact same quiet grin. For the rest of the two-week camp block—from the morning walk across Dominion Mall to afternoon *Four-in-a-Row Grid* and *Wild Draw* cards in the Fieldhouse multipurpose room—nobody at Virginia Dominion University ever tried to separate either pair of siblings again.

Big Family Christmas

The Newport News ARTS Train & The Downstairs Sofa Bed

Date: 1994-12-23 at 18:15 America/New_York

6:15 PM — The Newport News ARTS Platform

The evening train pulled into the brick ARTS—American Rail Transit Service—station in Newport News with a long hiss of air brakes and a cloud of white steam rising into the cold December air.

Up on the concrete platform, Katie and I stood side by side in our winter coats with our hands tucked into our pockets, watching the stainless-steel ARTS passenger doors slide open. Moments later, Grandma, our Aunt Elizabeth, and our nine-year-old cousin Chelsea stepped down onto the platform carrying their holiday suitcases, and the whole family crowded together to exchange hugs and greetings.

True to form, before we had even walked ten feet past the station canopy toward the parking lot, Aunt Elizabeth wasted no time digging into her coat pocket and lighting up a cigarette.

Beside us, Chelsea immediately scowled and angrily plugged her nose with two fingers.

“Mom, that’s gross,” Chelsea stammered, waving a hand in front of her face as all of us were forced to stand on the cold curb waiting before we could load into the vehicles.

“Liz, put that out,” our dad snapped, his breath fogging in the December chill as he hefted two suitcases into the trunk of our Holt sedan. “You know damn well that’s not good for you!”

“Alright, alright,” Aunt Liz snapped back, stubbing the cigarette out on the heel of her boot as we sorted ourselves into the two vehicles for the drive back across the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel.

Chelsea climbed into the middle of the back bench seat of the Holt sedan right between Katie and me, while Dad and Aunt Liz sat up front. Behind us, Mom—who was having a rare sober evening so Grandma wouldn’t ask questions at the ARTS station—drove Grandma in the pickup truck following our taillights down Interstate 64.

As soon as our sedan cleared the tunnel and turned onto the familiar streets of Virginia Beach, Katie leaned forward slightly to look across Chelsea at me, her eyes bright with holiday excitement.

“Welcome to Virginia Beach!” Katie squealed happily, squeezing Chelsea’s mittened hand. “Now, the three of us are going to have to squeeze into one room!”

8:00 PM — Downstairs Sanctuary

When we pulled into the driveway at home, Katie, Chelsea, and I pitched in right away to help Grandma and Aunt Liz carry their overnight bags through the front door.

Standing at the foot of the stairs in the foyer, Dad laid out the holiday room assignments.

“You three will share the sofa bed,” Dad said to us kids, gesturing toward the living room. Turning to the adults, he added, “Mom, Katie’s room is closer to the upstairs bathroom. Liz, you get Nathaniel’s room.”

In a lot of houses, getting evicted from both of our upstairs bedrooms for the holidays would have felt like a punishment. To Katie and me, however, Dad had just handed us the greatest logistical gift of Christmas. With Grandma in Katie’s room, Aunt Liz in my room, and Mom and Dad behind their closed door at the end of the upstairs hall, all four adults were confined to the second floor—which meant the entire first floor belonged exclusively to the three of us kids.

“Chelsea, there’s a bathroom down here we can use,” Katie explained immediately, pointing down the short hallway off the living room. “It has a shower. We can stay downstairs while the adults are upstairs.”

“Okay,” our cousin replied, setting her backpack by the couch. “Where do we sleep?”

“The three of us will sleep down here. This sofa is a sofa bed,” Katie replied proudly as the three of us finished carrying the last of the adults’ bags up the stairs.

Because the train had arrived late in the evening, dinner was fast and simple—warm bowls of soup and buttered rolls around the dining table—and before nine o’clock, the adults retreated upstairs for the night, leaving the first floor completely to the three of us.

“I want to take a shower,” Chelsea announced to Katie and me once the upstairs footsteps quieted down.

Katie walked her down the short hall to show her how to turn the downstairs shower faucet on and where the clean towels were stacked, then came back out into the living room where I had already changed into my long-sleeved flannel pajamas and was busy pulling the heavy metal frame of the sofa bed out from inside the couch. Working together, Katie and I unfolded the mattress, smoothed out the clean cotton sheets, and spread two thick winter quilts across the top.

A few minutes later, the bathroom door clicked open. Instead of putting her pajamas on inside the bathroom, Chelsea wandered straight out into the living room wrapped only in a bath towel, making her way casually toward the sofa bed Katie and I had just finished setting up.

“CHELSEA!” Katie stammered, her hand shooting out in a flash to clamp firmly over my eyes. “Your cousin shouldn’t be seeing all of you!”

Before Chelsea could even blink, Katie spun her right back around by the shoulders and shunted her straight back into the downstairs bathroom to finish drying off and put her flannel pajamas on properly.

“You need to stop blushing,” my twin sister admonished me once the bathroom door clicked shut behind Chelsea—except she didn’t truly admonish me at all, letting out a quiet, bubbly giggle as she took her hand off my face. “You promise not to tell anyone?”

“Promise,” I replied, rubbing the bridge of my nose as we both climbed onto the left side of the wide sofa bed in our flannel pajamas and pulled the heavy winter quilt up to our chins.

“You know Chelsea sometimes forgets the rules when she’s in a different house,” Katie whispered, leaning her head against my shoulder underneath the quilt and lacing her fingers through mine. “As long as we look out for each other down here, nobody upstairs is going to yell at anyone.”

“Not a word to anyone,” I whispered back, squeezing her hand.

Two minutes later, Chelsea came back out of the hallway wearing her full green flannel pajamas, fuzzy socks, and a sheepish grin, and climbed under the quilt on the far side of the sofa bed. With the living room lamp clicked off and only the colored lights of the Christmas tree glowing softly in the corner, Katie stayed tucked right against my side—the two of us holding down our downstairs sanctuary while the winter wind rattled the front windows.

Middle School & The Blizzard of ’96

The Blizzard of ’96

Snow Day in Virginia Beach & The Backyard Promise

Date: 1996-01-06 at 11:30 America/New_York

11:30 AM — Waiting for the First Flakes

“You think we’re going to have snow?” Katie asked, her breath fogging a small circle on the cold glass pane as the two of us stood shoulder to shoulder at my upstairs bedroom window.

“Hope so. SNOW DAY!” I said, practically vibrating with excitement as I pressed my palms against the wooden sill and looked out at our residential street in Virginia Beach.

Outside on the first Saturday of January 1996, it was bitterly cold, and heavy, slate-gray clouds were rolling in off the Atlantic until the sky looked like brushed steel. Behind us on my bedroom stand, the local Norfolk GBS news station had cut into regular Saturday morning programming, the meteorologist standing in front of a swirling radar map warning all of Hampton Roads to prepare for the Blizzard of ’96. Even on a Saturday, a real blizzard meant Monday and Tuesday would be wiped clean off the school calendar.

“Snow,” Katie replied hopefully, leaning her shoulder against mine as the news anchor continued to drone on and on about wind gusts, coastal flooding, and how many inches were expected later in the afternoon. Both of us were thrilled at the thought of the whole neighborhood shutting down.

At twelve-thirty, while Katie and I were sitting side by side at the kitchen table eating our lunch sandwiches, the first white flakes began to drift past the dining room window. At first it wasn't much—just fine, powdery crystals swirling across the dry grass—but within twenty minutes the flakes grew thick and steady, dusting the wooden fence rails and the roof of Dad's car.

"Wonder if it will stick," Katie giggled, pointing her finger toward the patio.

By late afternoon, it didn't just stick; it buried the entire backyard under a clean, silent blanket of white.

Inside the house, however, the quiet didn't last. Around five o'clock, the familiar, sharp sound of Mom's and Dad's voices started rising from the upstairs hallway—first a slammed cabinet door, then the bitter, overlapping shouting match that always followed whenever Dad found another empty bottle hidden behind the pantry cans.

5:45 PM — The Backyard Bear Hug

Katie and I didn't wait for the yelling to reach the staircase. We pulled on our heavy winter jackets and boots and slipped out the back door into the twilight snow.

Out in the backyard, inside the perimeter of our white wooden picket fence, the falling snow acted like a giant acoustic blanket over the neighborhood. The streetlamps glowed pale orange through the swirling flakes, and every footstep made a soft, muted crunch under our shoes.

Standing near the center of the yard with the snow settling onto my short blonde hair, the cold wind hit my face, and all at once the weight of everything we had been carrying over the past year caught up with me. My chest tightened, and before I could stop myself, I started sniffling in the cold air.

Katie turned around immediately. She didn't hesitate for a second—she stepped straight through the snow and pulled me into a tight, fierce bear hug, wrapping both of her blue-jacketed arms around my shoulders.

"What's wrong?" Katie asked softly against my ear, holding onto me with all her strength.

"I'm just so happy you're willing to do all of this for me," I whispered into her shoulder, my voice shaking slightly as I held onto the back of her winter coat, unsure of how to put the rest of the knot in my chest into words.

Katie didn't need me to explain it. Because she was my twin, she already knew the exact two things crushing my ribs.

"You're still upset with last year, and that girl everyone thought you had a crush on?" Katie asked gently.

"Yes, I am," I whimpered, burying my face against her collar, overwhelmingly grateful that my twin sister was hugging me instead of telling me to toughen up. All through the previous spring at school, a pack of kids in our grade had latched onto a rumor that I had a crush on a girl in our homeroom, turning every hallway change

and cafeteria period into a relentless, mocking gauntlet that wouldn't stop no matter what I said. "And it does not help that Mom and Dad are arguing with each other again. I just want to enjoy the snow without the screaming."

"I'm right here, and I will never leave you," Katie replied fiercely, pulling me into an even tighter bear hug as the heavy January snow came down all around us in the twilight. "I'm your sister, and I would just never, ever leave you."

She held onto me for a long moment in the quiet yard, letting the steady pressure of her arms slow my breathing down, before she spoke again.

"Your classmates are mean," Katie continued, her voice firm against the cold wind. "Especially when they refuse to back down. When we go back to school, I will gladly play my part of pretend girlfriend so they leave you alone."

"Thank you, but I think everyone knows that you're my sister," I whispered, managing a small, shaky laugh even as my teeth started chattering from the twenty-degree air.

"Come on, let's head back inside before we freeze," Katie said, taking my hand and leading me back across the snow-covered grass toward the back door.

Inside the warm kitchen, the shouting upstairs had finally stopped—Mom had gone to bed for the night, and the house was still again. Standing beside the dark green laminate counter with the snow piling up against the dining room window glass behind us, Katie wrapped her arms around my neck for one more long, warming hug until the chill left my fingers.

"Let's use my bed tonight," I whispered as we started walking up the stairs together. "This way we can see the street from my window when we wake up in the morning."

"Sure," Katie smiled. "I hope we wake up to snow on the ground like there is right now."

At the top of the landing, I paused outside my bedroom door and looked at her. "Real quick, if you're going to spend the night with me: what should we do about getting changed?"

"I'll go change into my warm pajamas in my room and grab my pillow, and I'll knock when I'm ready," Katie whispered with a practical nod.

Three minutes later, after I had pulled on my own heavy winter flannel pajamas and climbed under the covers by the window, three quiet knocks sounded against my door.

"Cartoons are for life," Katie whispered from the hall.

"Come on in," I whispered back.

Carrying her pillow under her arm in her purple fleece pajamas, Katie crossed the carpet and climbed under the heavy blanket right at my side. Outside my bedroom window, the Blizzard of '96 howled silently across Virginia Beach, piling deep drifts against the curb under the glow of the streetlamp, while inside the warm perimeter of my bed, my twin sister and I fell fast asleep holding hands.

Katie Is Dumped

No More Fighting & The Dinner Dance Promise

Date: 1997-10-16 at 16:15 America/New_York

4:15 PM — Tears Under the Blue Butterfly

“Leave me alone! You’d never understand,” Katie sobbed, turning her head half away as I pushed her bedroom door open and stepped onto the carpet.

I had just walked up the stairs after seventh grade when I heard the sound echoing right through her hollow wooden door into the upstairs hallway. Katie was standing near the foot of her bed against the bright magenta-purple wall beneath her framed blue morpho butterfly print, crying up a storm with her shoulders shaking inside her dark navy t-shirt and both hands pressed over her face.

For the first month of middle school—while I spent my afternoons quiet in my blue bedroom with my *Nova 64* video games and Katie tried her hardest to fit in with the girls from her English class and a seventh-grade boy named Donnie—the stress of the loud hallways and Mom’s worsening drinking at home had pushed the two of us into the stupid habit of bickering whenever we passed each other in the hall.

Hearing the ragged sound of her crying, I dropped every trace of that irritation at the door. Stepping quietly across her room, I placed my hand gently on her shoulder.

“What is it?” I asked softly.

Katie continued sobbing for several seconds, her chest heaving as she tried to catch her breath. I realized immediately that this wasn’t a small hallway argument—this was serious. It took her a long moment to realize that I wasn’t going to tease her or make fun of her for crying.

Slowly, she lowered her hands from her tear-streaked face.

“Donnie dumped me,” Katie choked out, fresh tears spilling down her cheeks. “I loved him, and he dumped me!”

I reached my hand out to gently wipe the tears from her eyes. Never having had a girlfriend myself—and never having been dumped—I didn’t fully understand the mechanics of middle-school romance, but I didn’t need to understand romance to see how badly my twin sister was hurting.

Katie reached out with both hands and took mine, holding onto my fingers tightly as if she were drowning and I was the only solid ground in the room.

“Please… don’t let go,” she whispered, her voice raw.

I closed both of my hands around hers and held on firmly. Looking straight into my eyes with a sudden, desperate seriousness, Katie asked the question that mattered most to survival in a middle-school cafeteria:

“Will you sit with me at lunch?”

The look on Katie's upset face told me the only answer she needed to hear—and it was the exact answer I wanted to give her anyway.

"Yes," I answered without hesitation. "I'll sit with you at lunch."

Katie burst into fresh tears of pure relief, letting go of my fingers only to throw both arms around my neck and pull me into a tight hug.

"Thank you," she whispered against my shoulder.

I could hear how raspy and sore her throat was from all of her crying, so I offered to run downstairs and get her a cold glass of water, but she shook her head and held onto my shirt even tighter. As I wrapped my arms around her waist and hugged her back in the quiet room, I felt something shift permanently inside my chest. All the petty squabbling we had done over the past few weeks felt completely, utterly stupid. Katie didn't want to stop hugging me, and I didn't have a single problem with that.

"Please, no more fighting," my sister sobbed softly into my shoulder.

"I understand," I promised, resting my chin against the top of her blonde hair as we continued to hold onto each other.

"I'm still upset, but thanks for this," Katie murmured a minute later as I felt a few more warm tears soak into the shoulder of my maroon t-shirt.

"Katie, I'm here for you," I told her. And as I said the words out loud, squeezing my arms around my twin sister, I realized just how much more I loved hugging her and keeping her safe than arguing with her.

5:00 PM — The Pretend Date & PB&J Sanctuary

When her crying finally began to subside, the two of us sat down side by side on the edge of her green-and-gold patterned bedspread, our shoulders pressed together and our hands still linked.

"Thank you," Katie said quietly, wiping her eyes with the back of her wrist. "Thank you for being there for me. Someday, I know I'm going to repay this."

She went quiet for a beat, looking down at our joined hands, before she suddenly whispered:

"Take me to the Dinner Dance this week."

The seventh-grade Dinner Dance was tomorrow night in the school cafeteria, and half the reason Katie had been crying so hard was the thought of either staying home alone in embarrassment or walking into that room by herself while Donnie was there.

"Of course we can go together," I said immediately, knowing I didn't have a date of my own—and wouldn't have wanted to go with anyone else even if I did. "Even though you're my sister, we will go on a pretend date."

“Oh, thank you. Thank you,” Katie breathed, the last of the heavy sobs finally leaving her chest as she leaned her head against my shoulder.

“Would you like it if I made you dinner tonight?” I asked, deciding right then and there to start playing my part as her protective pretend boyfriend.

“Let’s just have something simple, like sandwiches,” she said softly.

“Alright,” I replied, giving her hand a gentle squeeze as the two of us stood up and headed downstairs together.

In the quiet kitchen, I made us both thick peanut-butter-and-jelly sandwiches and poured two tall glasses of cold milk to soothe her sore throat. After we finished eating at the table, Katie looked across at me.

“Could we watch a movie together?” she asked.

“Sure,” I replied warmly. “Let’s pick something together.”

We walked back upstairs to my deep-blue bedroom, picked out our VHS tape of *House Guard 2: Lost in Manhattan* from the shelf beneath my television stand, and pushed it into the VCR. As the opening Majestic Studios credits began to roll across the CRT screen, Katie kicked off her shoes and climbed into my single bed right at my side, resting her head on my shoulder and pulling the blanket across our legs.

Near the end of the movie, when the closing music faded in, I glanced down and saw that my sister was fast asleep against my arm, her breathing slow and completely peaceful after an afternoon of crying her eyes out.

I reached carefully for the remote, clicked the television off, and decided right then to let her sleep. I decided that I would tell her that I didn’t mind after we woke up in the morning. Katie was exhausted, and the last thing I wanted was to see her become a grouch because she was woken back up without enough sleep. Part of me marveled at how natural it felt sharing my narrow bed with my twin sister again—just like we had during the Blizzard of ’96 and on the downstairs sofa bed at Christmas. We had chosen this close brother-and-sister bond together, and enjoying the warm, quiet company of the person who mattered most to me in the world, I slid down onto the pillow beside her and let myself drift off to sleep at her side.

The Pretend Boyfriend & Twins’ Day

Twin Brothers Always Stay: Spirit Week & The Living Room Sofa

Date: 1997-10-17 at 07:30 America/New_York

7:30 AM — “Twin Brothers Always Stay”

The next morning, when the pale autumn sunlight filtered through the blinds of my bedroom, I woke up first—and sure enough, Katie was still fast asleep right at my side in the small bed.

“Katie,” I whispered softly, gently prodding her shoulder so I wouldn’t startle her in case she didn’t realize right away that she had fallen asleep in my room the night before.

My sister stirred against the pillow, blinking her blue eyes open in the quiet blue room before looking from the wall to me in mild surprise.

“Morning, sleepyhead,” I whispered with a small smile.

“I slept in your bed?” she asked groggily, rubbing her eyes.

“Yep, and I did not mind,” I replied, looking her straight in the eye. “Let’s play a game together.”

For the first time since Donnie had broken her heart yesterday afternoon, Katie’s face lit up with genuine excitement. While she sat up against the headboard, I slipped out of bed, walked across the carpet to the television stand, and powered on my *Nova 64* video game console. I was still in full protective-brother mode, determined to keep cheering her up until I heard her laugh again.

Before I picked up the controller, I turned back to face her.

“I’m your brother. I will always be here for you. Promise,” I told her, my voice steady and earnest in the quiet room. I paused for half a beat, then added the truth I knew we would live by for the rest of our lives: “Boyfriends come and go, but Twin Brothers always stay. Always.”

Before the console title screen had even finished loading on the CRT television, I found myself wrapped in Katie’s arms again. She stood up from the edge of the mattress and hugged me with everything she had, making it unmistakably clear that she had no intention of letting go of me. She held onto my shoulders while the video game rolled through its opening demo sequence on the screen behind us, then sat down on the carpet right at my side.

“We should probably get dressed,” Katie said after a moment, glancing down at her wrinkled shirt from yesterday. “Guess I will pop into my room real quick. Leave the game on this screen while we get dressed?”

“Sure,” I replied, gently ushering her to the bedroom door. “I’ll open my door when I’m dressed.”

8:00 AM — Spirit Week: Twins’ Day

Five minutes later, after I had pulled on a clean maroon short-sleeve t-shirt, medium-wash blue jeans, and my tan sneakers, I opened my bedroom door. Katie walked right back in from across the hall—and the second I saw what she had picked out of her closet, I had to grin.

Without planning it, she had put on the exact same shade of maroon short-sleeve t-shirt and medium-wash blue jeans with a dark belt.

“Next week is Spirit Week at school,” I said as she stepped into the room. “Want to have a little fun on Twins’ Day, since, well, we *are* twins?”

Katie giggled as I handed her the second black controller from the floor stand. “Yeah, we are twins! Wonder how many others will really be twins compared to how many will do it just for fun.”

We both laughed out loud at that remark, and right there in front of my computer desk and television stand, we stubbornly made up our minds.

“I think it’s settled, then,” I declared. “We will dress exactly the same, and we will enter the contest.”

We laughed again, already looking forward to seeing how the teachers and our classmates would react to actual fraternal twins walking into the Spirit Week Twins’ Day assembly dressed identically and holding hands.

“Too bad we don’t have matching shoes,” Katie remarked, looking down at her grey-and-red sneakers next to my tan ones.

“Ah, well. Still, let’s do what we can. I think these pants and shirts look close enough,” I said, setting the controllers on the desk and pulling her into another tight, standing hug in the middle of the room. Both of us laughed into each other’s shoulders, our matching maroon sleeves wrapped around each other’s backs. Yesterday’s tears were completely gone.

5:30 PM — Macaroni & Cheese on the Living Room Sofa

Later that evening, after spending the afternoon practicing our co-op levels and getting ready for the weekend, Katie and I walked downstairs and decided to sit together on the tan-brown living room sofa, curling up side by side while we waited for dinner to be made.

As usual in our house, Dad was in the kitchen working over the stove after a full day at his job, while upstairs Mom was already passed out drunk in bed behind her closed door.

“Mac and cheese is what I smell,” I whispered as Katie slid flush against my right side on the sofa cushions, draped her left arm warmly around my shoulders, and rested her right hand across my forearm to hold me close to her.

“Our favorite,” she replied softly, resting her cheek near my shoulder as the two of us sat there, happily snuggled up together beneath the blue-framed underwater painting on the living room wall.

We had a few quiet minutes to ourselves before the timer on the stove went off, and neither of us wanted to get off the sofa. After years of feeling like we had to keep our guard up against loud classrooms and the unpredictable storms upstairs, snuggling together on the couch felt like the safest, most comfortable place on earth.

As we sat there in the warm glow of the living room lamp, Katie whispered, “Snuggling up is just so comfortable.”

“It is,” I replied quietly, leaning into the warmth of her arm around my shoulders. Neither of us moved an inch; we were both completely content holding onto each other and letting the rest of the house fade away.

A few minutes later, Dad stepped to the doorway of the dining room with a pot holder in his hand, looking over at the two of us curled up together on the couch before calling us in to eat.

When we sat down side by side at the dining table over our steaming bowls of macaroni and cheese, Dad looked across the table at the two of us, his tired eyes softening with genuine gratitude.

“I really appreciate that you both don’t fight and argue with each other,” Dad said quietly, his voice heavy with emotion. “Honestly, I wish your mother didn’t drink her life away. I want to do my best to not only be your father, but also be a proper dad to both of you. Your mother’s drinking is not your fault, and I don’t want either of you to think that. Please don’t let your grades suffer because of it.”

Underneath the edge of the dining table, Katie reached her hand over and laced her fingers tightly through mine, and I squeezed right back. Whatever happened upstairs, and whatever happened in the hallways at school, my twin sister and I had our sanctuary—and we were never letting go.

Sixteen & Summer Sanctuary

Bonding With My Sister

Summer Sanctuary: Hearthstone Pizza, The Sunlit Valley, & Katie’s Room

Date: 2001-06-18 at 08:30 America/New_York

8:30 AM — First Full Day of Summer

“Summer is here,” I said, blinking open my eyes as the warm June sunlight filtered through the blinds of Katie’s bedroom.

“Our first full day with the house to ourselves,” my sister replied softly as we started waking up.

Having both turned sixteen back on April eighth, the two of us were curled up side by side in our pajamas on top of her green-and-gold patterned bedspread beneath the framed blue morpho butterfly artwork hanging on her magenta-purple wall, completely used to being pretend dates and full-time anchors for each other. With both of our parents already gone for their morning shifts and two quiet weeks stretching ahead of us before Summer School started, the entire house was finally calm.

Katie rubbed her eyes, then looked over at me and asked, “Get dressed and have breakfast?”

“Sure, I am getting hungry,” I replied, giving her hand a quick squeeze as I climbed out of bed.

I stepped across the upstairs hallway into my own deep-blue painted bedroom to pull on a clean maroon crew-neck t-shirt and jeans while Katie changed in her room, and two minutes later we met right back at her doorway, exchanging a warm, familiar smile before making our way down the stairs together.

“Let’s just have some cereal, then we will figure out what we want to do for the day,” I said as we reached the bottom landing. “I want to spend the day with just you.”

Our stomachs were calling us, as was our daily routine of taking our morning dose of medication before the day got underway. In the quiet kitchen, I pulled two ceramic bowls out from the cupboard and set our morning medication tablets beside two glasses of water while we picked out our cereal from the pantry—being twins, of course it was the exact same box—and sat down at the kitchen table, pulling our chairs right up against each other so we were as close as possible.

After we took our morning medication and started on our cereal, my twin sister reached across the table, took my hand, and looked straight into my eyes.

“What would you like to do today?” Katie asked.

“I was thinking of snuggling on the sofa over a movie,” I suggested as we continued eating our breakfast side by side.

“I know just the movie I want to watch,” my sister said, squeezing my hand. She gave me that unmistakable look like she had a big secret and started giggling. She wanted me to ask what movie it was, but after sixteen years as her twin brother, I knew she wouldn’t tell me—I would have to wait and see what it was when she popped the tape into the VCR.

Since I had made breakfast, Katie took it upon herself to carry our bowls and spoons over to the counter and load our dishes into the dishwasher.

“I will get the tape, then will join you on the sofa,” Katie called over her shoulder as I headed toward the living room.

“Alright, Katie,” I replied, settling onto the cushions of our tan-brown living room sofa beside the coffee table, where Dad had neatly stacked the slightly outdated *Quantum Basic 5.0* programming textbooks—complete with clear plastic mylar covers and barcode stickers on the spines—that he had checked out from the Virginia Beach Public Library to get a head start on his upcoming fall *Quantum Basic 6.0* class at the Community College of Hampton Roads—CCHR. Over the past few weeks, Katie had started reading Dad’s library books cover to cover and teaching the programming exercises to me, and when Dad found out, he had beamed with pride and actively encouraged both of us to keep coding.

Even better, when Summer School started in two weeks, Katie and I weren’t going because we were behind. We had intentionally signed up to knock out an academic credit over the summer so that when our main high-school year started in September, our schedules would line up with a free period and lunch block together every single day. Until those summer classes began, I was looking forward to having unbroken time with my twin sister.

9:30 AM — *Hearthstone Pizza & Journey to the Sunlit Valley*

A minute later, Katie walked into the living room holding a familiar white clamshell VHS tape behind her back, slid the cassette into the VCR beneath the television, and walked over to sit on the sofa right next to me.

Immediately, she lifted her arm and made it clear she wanted me to snuggle up in her arms. I slid flush against her side and rested my head against her shoulder, glad that I got to curl up with Katie now that the two of us had become so close.

Across the room, the CRT television flickered to life. My eyes lit up as the sweeping orchestral welcome theme to one of our favorite companies—*Majestic Studios*—played across the screen, and then my eyes lit up even further as the previews transitioned and I recognized the exact childhood VHS movie that my sister had put on for us: *Journey to the Sunlit Valley*.

“I knew you would like it,” Katie whispered, resting her cheek against my hair as she looked down into my eyes.

“Of course,” I whispered back with a grin as the tape rolled through its iconic opening bumper before the feature presentation—the familiar, upbeat birthday party commercial from *Hearthstone Pizza* where the older brother was supposed to be nice to the little girl.

We happily stayed curled up together on the cushions as Sprout and his friends began their journey across the screen, wanting nothing more than to sit there quietly in each other’s arms watching the movie. Both of our parents were away at work, the house was completely peaceful, and we had decided that all we wanted was each other—just brother-and-sister time together in our sanctuary before Summer School was set to begin.

9:00 PM — Katie’s Room Beneath the Blue Butterfly

By the time evening rolled around and the June twilight faded outside the living room windows, we had spent the entire day side by side without a single argument, a single raised voice, or a single interruption from the outside world.

As we walked up the stairs together after dinner and paused on the second-floor landing between my blue-painted bedroom and her magenta-purple bedroom, Katie turned to me and took my hand.

“Share a bed?” Katie asked softly.

“Sure,” I replied without hesitation. “Your room or mine?”

“How about my room tonight,” Katie suggested with a gentle smile.

After I stepped into my blue room to brush my teeth and change into a comfortable t-shirt and flannel pajama pants, I crossed the hall and knocked lightly on Katie’s door. Inside her room, under the warm amber glow of the bedside lamp and the framed blue morpho butterfly on her wall, we climbed onto her bed together, propped our pillows against the headboard, and pulled the green-and-gold covers

across our legs. Katie draped her arm around my shoulders and laced her fingers through mine, and as the house settled into quiet around us, we drifted off to sleep side by side.

End of Summer Cruise

Part 1: Part 1: The I-95 Haul, The Quantum Basic Library Book, & Ditching Captain Barnaby

Date: 2001-08-19 at 09:30 America/New_York

Saturday, August 18, 2001 — The Twelve-Hour Grumble Down I-95

“If `Command1_Click` calls the subroutine before the text box validates, the whole form throws a type-mismatch error,” Katie murmured beside me in the back seat of our Holt sedan, tapping her finger against page 142 of the thick paperback resting across our knees as another green Florida mileage sign flashed past the window on Interstate 95 South.

“That’s only in *Quantum Basic 5.0*,” our dad, David Prairie, called back from the driver’s seat, his eyes flicking warmly to the rearview mirror despite the fatigue of ten straight hours behind the wheel. “Wait until we test it on the *Quantum Basic 6.0* compiler at the CCHR lab next month. Though I’ll be honest with you two—I’d a whole lot rather be sitting at our kitchen table in Virginia Beach testing that code right now than driving to Port Canaveral.”

“So would we, Dad,” I grumbled, shifting my stiff legs on the bench seat while Katie laced her left hand through my right.

None of the three of us—not Dad, not Katie, and not me—had wanted to go on this seven-day Caribbean cruise at the end of August. Back in July, Katie and I had worked hard through our high-school summer school class, knocking out a required academic credit early so that when eleventh grade started in September, our main school-year schedules would free up for a shared lunch block together every single day. All the three of us had wanted for the final two weeks of summer was to stay home in peace so Dad could study for his upcoming fall semester at the Community College of Hampton Roads—CCHR.

To get a head start before classes began, Dad had gone to the Virginia Beach Public Library and checked out the newest programming manual they had left on the shelf—a slightly outdated, dog-eared copy of *Learn Quantum Basic 5.0 in 21 Days* wrapped in a clear plastic mylar library jacket with a barcode sticker on the spine. Within forty-eight hours of Dad setting that book on the dining table, Katie had started reading it cover to cover and teaching the event loops and form layouts to me on my bedroom computer. When Dad caught us working through his library book together, he hadn’t been upset at all; he had beamed with pride and started actively encouraging both of us to follow our dreams.

Up in the front passenger seat, however, our mother, Brenda, hadn’t cared about Dad’s CCHR classes, our summer school credit, or the fact that twelve hours crammed into a sedan was making Katie’s and my legs ache from hip to ankle. Mom

had insisted on booking this seven-day Eastern Caribbean cruise—and when we finally rolled over the causeway into Port Canaveral on Saturday afternoon, the visual irony hit Katie and me right through the windshield.

Docked at the premier terminal across the blue channel stood a gleaming, navy-and-gold *Majestic Cruise Line* ship, its twin funnels shining in the Florida sun.

We didn't turn into the *Majestic* terminal. Instead, Mom directed Dad toward Pier 3, where a boxy, bargain-rate mass-market ship called the *M/S Sunward Tropics* was loading passengers.

By four o'clock that afternoon, standing packed shoulder-to-shoulder in bulky orange foam lifejackets out on the humid teak planks of the Deck 4 Boat Promenade for the mandatory twenty-minute safety muster drill—with all of the ship's elevators shut off—I felt the first warning tremor shoot down both of my calves. Beside me, Katie was leaning almost her entire weight against my right arm just to keep her knees locked. Both of us had lived with mild cerebral palsy since birth, which had always made our balance uneven, but standing on that hot deck before climbing two flights of metal stairs back to our cramped inside cabin left our legs shaking and our arms strangely weak on the brass banisters in a way neither of us had ever felt before.

Dad walked right behind us up every step of the stairwell, one hand braced behind Katie's back and the other steadying my elbow, his brow furrowed with quiet concern as he watched how hard our arms were straining just to pull ourselves up the railing.

Sunday, August 19, 2001, 9:30 AM — Ditching *Captain Barnaby* for the Deck 8 CyberCafé

"Look at the two of you—you're going to be late for the character breakfast!" Mom snapped at nine-twenty on Sunday morning, shoving two neon-yellow *"Camp Sunward Youth"* lanyards and a printed activity sheet into Dad's hand before disappearing out the cabin door toward the Lido Pool Bar. "And I put Katie's name down for the two o'clock beginner ballet and ballroom workshop in the Starlight Lounge!"

Katie stared at the pink dance slip in horror, her fingers tightening around my wrist as the ship rolled gently on its first full day at sea heading toward Nassau.

"Come on," Dad said quietly, his jaw tight as he picked up his canvas backpack—with the Virginia Beach Public Library *Quantum Basic 5.0* book tucked inside—and led Katie and me down the narrow corridor to the elevator. "Let's go see what your mother signed you up for."

Five minutes later, the three of us stood outside the double glass doors of the Starlight Lounge on Deck 6.

Inside, thirty screaming six- and seven-year-olds were banging plastic spoons against paper placemats while accordion music blared from the speakers. Waddling between the tables were two sweaty crew members zipped into bargain-bin polyester foam mascot suits—*Captain Barnaby the Buccaneer Parrot* and *Salty the Starfish*—whose faded fabric looked like it had been pulled out of a carnival dumpster.

At the podium by the door, a twenty-two-year-old youth counselor glanced down at her clipboard—where Mom had written *Prairie, Nathaniel* and *Prairie, Katie*—and then looked up at two sixteen-year-old high schoolers standing side by side in t-shirts and jeans. Her face turned bright red with second-hand embarrassment.

Dad took one look through the glass doors at the foam parrot, looked at Katie's and my mortified faces, and didn't hesitate for half a second.

"Take those yellow lanyards off, kids," Dad said calmly.

Stepping up to the podium, Dad handed the lanyards back to the relieved counselor, drew a clean line through both of our names on the character breakfast roster, and asked her to cross Katie's name off the afternoon ballet workshop sheet as well.

"Where are the computers and the arcade cabinets on this ship?" Dad asked the counselor.

"Deck 8 Midship, sir—right next to the quiet library and card room," she replied gratefully.

Ten minutes later, sitting side by side in two padded armchairs inside the air-conditioned quiet of the Deck 8 CyberCafé overlooking the deep blue Atlantic, Katie and I finally exhaled. Dad swiped his cabin card to buy two hours of desktop terminal time, pulled the thick, mylar-wrapped *Quantum Basic 5.0* library textbook out of his bag, and set it open on the desk right between our keyboards.

While Mom spent the entire Sunday at sea up at the pool bar, the three of us spent the afternoon right there by the ocean windows—Katie pointing out how to nest `For...Next` loops on the screen, my fingers typing the syntax into the editor, and Dad sitting right beside us smiling with genuine pride.

Part 2: Part 2: The Nassau Pier, Guest Services, & The Last Straw

Date: 2001-08-22 at 14:00 America/Puerto_Rico

Monday–Wednesday, August 20–22, 2001 — The Nassau Pier & The Honest Question

"Hold onto my arm, Nate—don't look down at the concrete," Katie breathed against my shoulder as the ninety-two-degree Bahamas sun beat straight down onto the endless gray concrete expanse of Prince George Wharf in Nassau on Monday morning.

Ahead of us, Mom was already a hundred yards down the pier, marching briskly toward the duty-free liquor stores and open-air bars along Bay Street without once looking back to see where her children were. Halfway between the ship's gangway and the terminal gate, my right knee buckled without warning. When Katie tried to catch my weight with both hands, her own wrists gave out, and both of us nearly went down onto the hot concrete before Dad caught us under the arms and guided us onto a shaded wooden bench beside the port tram stop.

“Neither of you is walking another step in this heat,” Dad said firmly, kneeling down to check our trembling ankles before flagging down the port courtesy shuttle and hiring an air-conditioned island van driver to take just the three of us over the bridge to the step-free underwater glass aquarium tunnel on Paradise Island.

Over the next forty-eight hours—as the ship steamed south from the Bahamas toward Charlotte Amalie in St. Thomas and Philipsburg in St. Maarten—the gap between what Mom wanted and what our bodies could handle grew wider by the hour. Every time the ship rolled in the Caribbean swell, walking the long metal passageways felt like wading through wet cement, while Mom spent every afternoon running up the cabin bar tab and complaining whenever she passed us that Katie wasn’t attending the ship’s dance classes.

On Wednesday afternoon, Dad collected Katie and me outside the Deck 8 arcade, led us to a quiet, shaded alcove of deck chairs, and looked straight at the two of us.

“Please be honest,” Dad asked quietly. “Are you two not enjoying the cruise?”

When Katie and I looked at each other and struggled to come up with an answer, Dad leaned forward and rested his hands on his knees.

“I want to let you both in on how I feel,” Dad said earnestly. “Katie, this especially goes for you. I watched you teach your brother the *Quantum Basic* programming that I am learning in school at CCHR, and I am absolutely encouraging both of you to keep at it if you both like it. I see that your mother is trying to talk you into being a ballerina, but I get that you don’t want to.”

“I don’t have the balance to dance,” Katie said honestly, looking down at her sneakers. Mom still refused to accept that we had cerebral palsy—let alone whatever was making our arms and legs grow weaker this summer—insisting she saw two completely healthy kids. “I like this coding thing.”

“And I am encouraging you with this coding thing… I am encouraging both of you,” Dad said warmly.

“I didn’t appreciate that Mom tried booking us on the kid stuff,” I added, thinking back to the foam parrot mascot at Sunday morning’s breakfast door. “Katie and I are sixteen and already in high school, and I don’t want to meet the characters. It’s not even the characters that little kids want to meet, because it’s not *Majestic Cruise Line*! I want to play the computer games.”

“I get it,” Dad said, nodding firmly. He took a deep breath, his expression turning solemn. “There is something else I wanted to confide in both of you, and that is Mom’s drinking issue. Our next stop will be the front counter where I want to attempt to cut off the flow of alcohol to your mother.”

2:45 PM — Cutting Off the Flow at the Front Counter

The process at the Purser’s Desk in the Deck 5 Atrium Lobby seemed to drag on forever, and Katie and I found a padded seat across the lobby while we waited for Dad to be finished.

Because every bar on the ship operated on cashless plastic stateroom keycards—and because Dad's *Anchor Federal Credit Union* card was the sole payment method guaranteeing our cabin's Master Folio—Dad had the authority as the primary account holder to revoke all charging privileges on Mom's keycard and have the Watch Purser place a mandatory alcohol cut-off flag on her passenger ID across the ship's point-of-sale network.

When Dad finally walked back over to our bench, he held out three plastic cabin keycards, each newly stamped with a small holographic fountain-cup sticker.

"I bought the three of us a soda package, and we can get sodas and juice every fifteen minutes," Dad told us. "Your mother is going to be mad, but I don't care. I am so sorry to both of you that it is turning out like this, but I have to protect both of you."

Sitting down beside us for a moment, Dad lowered his voice to a quiet whisper.

"I know that you two have decided that you are inseparable, and I am okay with that, and I won't tell the world about your little secret," Dad whispered, looking at Katie and me with steady, unconditional protective warmth. "Yes, I know, and I think I've known for a while. Just don't go blabbing to everyone, and be careful with things."

3:30 PM — The Corridor Breakdown & The Ultimatum

The three of us rode the elevator down to Deck 4 and walked to our stateroom—and to our horror, though not to our surprise, when Dad opened the door, our mother was passed out drunk across the three-cushion convertible sofa that was supposed to unfold into the bed that Katie and I shared at night.

"Oh, I've had enough of your mother's nonsense," Dad said, pulling the door shut and turning Katie and me right around in the passageway.

We walked a long way through a narrow, windowless maze of identical stateroom hallways—our legs trembling and our feet stumbling against the carpet seams with every roll of the ship—until we finally reached a quiet stairwell seating alcove and sat down on the built-in bench.

Right there under the brass wall sconces, Dad buried his face in his hands and absolutely lost it, breaking down and crying.

Katie and I were completely at a loss for words. Our mental image of Daddy being tough and unbreakable came crashing down all at once, and for the first time in our sixteen years, we were seeing the exhausted, hurting human side of our father.

Katie and I sat close against his sides on the bench and just waited, holding hands because this was something neither of us knew how to respond to.

"I guess it will have to be a cruise for three," Katie whispered softly to me.

“Yeah, I guess,” I whispered back to my sister. We both looked over at our father, who was the most upset we had ever seen him in our lives. I didn’t even remember crying this hard when taking a bad fall on the pavement, and yet here the three of us were.

“I’ll try my best to handle this. Daddy needs us right now,” Katie whispered, resting her hand on Dad’s arm. “This is going to be a long and painful cruise.”

That was when we heard a screaming rage echoing down the metal hallway toward our alcove.

“The heck was that?” I asked, my heart jumping as a startled Katie looked up beside me.

“Where is my fucking beer?!”

Our mother had woken up from her drunken nap on our sofa, stormed up to the nearest deck bar, discovered that her keycard had been cut off at the register, and tracked us down the corridor—drunkenly screeching at our visibly upset father.

Dad wiped his eyes and stood up straight in front of our bench, placing himself squarely between our mother and the two of us.

“I’ve had enough, and so have the kids,” Dad said, his voice steady and resolute. “This cruise was supposed to be family time, and the three of us are tired of your drinking. Nathaniel, Katie, and I are giving you a choice: us, or the alcohol.”

Mom glared at us and slurred something bitter that none of us could even understand.

“Message received,” Dad said flatly. “You pick the bottle over your husband and children.”

Turning his back on her, Dad looked down at Katie and me and reached out both hands to help us stand up as our mother drunkenly stumbled away down the hall.

“Come on, you two,” Dad said gently. “I want you to show me what you two would like to do.”

As he supported our elbows and led Katie and me away down the passage, Dad made a vow that neither of us would ever forget.

“I’m making both of you a promise: I want to be a dad, and I want you both to help guide me through this,” Dad said quietly. “It will be painful, but your mother does not seem to want to be a mom. I’m sorry, but I have to do right by both of you.”

Holding onto Dad’s arms as our exhausted legs shook beneath us, the three of us stumbled through what felt like an endless hallway of cabins until we finally stumbled out into the bright light of the lobby.

Part 3: Part 3: Stateroom 6004, The Loaner Wheelchairs, & Pizza for Three on the Aft Deck

Date: 2001-08-23 at 18:30 America/Puerto_Rico

Wednesday, August 22, 2001, 4:15 PM — Domestic Separation, The Brig, & Two Manual Wheelchairs

“My kids can barely stand up after walking down that Deck 4 corridor, and my wife is screaming profanities at us in the passageway,” Dad told the Chief Purser flatly as the three of us reached the front counter in the Atrium Lobby, my knees trembling so badly that I had both hands braced against the marble counter edge while Katie leaned against my side. “I am not putting my son and daughter back in Stateroom 4118 with her tonight. I don’t want her in the cabin with us anymore.”

The Chief Purser glanced down at the black security radio clipped to his lapel, took one look at Dad’s raw, red-rimmed eyes and one look at Katie and me struggling to stay upright on our feet, and immediately picked up a brass master key.

“Deck 4 Security just radioed up about the disturbance in the passageway, Mr. Prairie,” the Chief Purser said quietly. “We hold two wheelchair-accessible contingency staterooms right off the Deck 6 midship elevators for medical and family safety emergencies. I am placing a confidential Domestic Separation Flag on your manifest right now and moving you, Nathaniel, and Katie into Stateroom 6004. Only your three soda-package keycards will open that door, and our staff is strictly prohibited from disclosing your new cabin number to your wife.”

Dad let out a long breath of pure relief, then glanced down at Katie’s shaking ankles and mine.

“Is there any chance the ship has two manual wheelchairs my twins can use for the rest of the cruise?” Dad asked, looking back at Katie and me to make sure we agreed.

Both Katie and I nodded immediately. Neither of us cared what strangers on a cruise ship thought—we were exhausted from fighting our own legs every time we crossed a deck.

“Consider it done, sir,” the Chief Purser replied. “I’ll have the Medical Center bring two folding *SwiftChair* manual wheelchairs straight up to Stateroom 6004 while our stewards transfer your bags and your library books from Deck 4.”

By five o’clock that afternoon, Dad, Katie, and I were safely upstairs inside Stateroom 6004—a wide, quiet room five steps from the elevator lobby with a clean double sofa bed that unfolded without a single obstacle and two folding manual wheelchairs waiting by the door.

At seven-fifteen that evening, while Katie and I were sitting together on the sofa bed reading Dad’s *Quantum Basic 5.0* library book, a polite knock sounded on our cabin door. When Dad opened it, the Chief Purser stood in the corridor with a clipboard under his arm.

“I wanted to check on you and the twins in person, Mr. Prairie, and let you know that you won’t have to worry about running into your wife on the decks for the rest of the voyage,” the Chief Purser told Dad evenly, his voice carrying clearly to where Katie and I sat. “About an hour ago, Mrs. Prairie returned to Stateroom 4118, found your luggage gone, and came down to the Atrium Lobby after her keycard was declined at the Lido Bar. When we refused to disclose your new cabin number or

unblock her alcohol privileges, she tried to climb over the Purser's counter and swung a fist at one of our Security officers. The Staff Captain has placed her in the ship's brig down on Deck 2."

Katie's hand tightened around mine on the sofa cushion as we listened.

"Because we have already cleared our final Caribbean port of call and are steaming north," the Chief Purser continued, "she will remain in security custody until we dock at Port Canaveral on Saturday morning, where she will be escorted off the vessel and handed a permanent lifetime ban from *Sunward Cruise Lines*. I also want to assure you, Nathaniel, and Katie that your names are completely clear—none of the three of you are excluded from sailing with us in the future."

Dad thanked him quietly and closed the door. Mom had managed to get herself banned from a cruise line yet again—not that Dad, Katie, or I ever wanted to set foot on a cruise ship again in the first place.

Thursday, August 23, 2001, 6:30 PM — Pizza & Soda Refills on the Aft Deck

"Two pepperoni slices, two extra-cheese slices, and three fifteen-minute fountain refills—two colas and an orange juice," Dad announced with a genuine smile on Thursday evening as he set a steaming stainless-steel pizza platter and three tall plastic tumblers down on our round table out on the open wooden aft deck.

Sitting side by side in our two ship-provided folding manual wheelchairs right at the back rail of Deck 9, watching the white foaming wake of the ship stretch out across the turquoise Caribbean Sea under a golden-orange sunset, Katie and I reached across the space between our wheelchair armrests and laced our fingers together.

Inside the main dining rooms tonight was Captain's Formal Night, where hundreds of passengers were crammed into noisy banquet halls in stiff suits and high heels. Out here on the breezy fantail deck, wearing comfortable t-shirts and jeans with zero pain in our calves or knees thanks to the manual wheelchairs, the last two days of the voyage had finally become what Katie had whispered in the corridor alcove: a peaceful cruise for three.

"How do the chairs feel?" Dad asked softly, pulling his deck chair right up beside our wheels and picking up a slice of pizza.

"So much better, Dad," Katie said, leaning her head briefly against my shoulder as she took a sip from her straw. "My legs aren't shaking at all."

"Mine either," I agreed, looking down at our three soda-sticker keycards resting together on the table next to Dad's library copy of *Quantum Basic 5.0*. For the first time all week, nobody was yelling, nobody was trying to force Katie to dance or shove us into a room with foam parrot mascots, and as the warm ocean breeze blew past the stern rail, the three of us talked for two straight hours about the programs we were going to write when we got home to Virginia Beach.

Part 4: Part 4: Back on Dry Land & The Twelve-Hour Drive Up I-95

Date: 2001-08-25 at 08:30 America/New_York

Saturday, August 25, 2001, 8:30 AM — Back on Dry Land

“Nathaniel. Katie. I’m sorry that your first cruise was wrecked, and somehow I want to make it up to both of you,” Dad said earnestly as two crew members helped us transfer out of the ship’s loaner wheelchairs onto the gray cloth back bench seat of our Holt sedan at the Port Canaveral pickup curb. Resting a steady hand on each of our shoulders through the open door, Dad continued, “Here is what we will do: neither one of you wanted to go on that cruise, but your mother insisted. I want to finish school at CCHR so that I can do a better job at being a dad without having to worry about money as much.”

Before Katie or I could answer him, an angry screech tore across the concrete baggage drop from behind us.

“You! You told the ship to stop my drinks!”

Looking through the open rear doorway, I saw our mother being escorted out of the customs terminal doors by two *Sunward Cruise Lines* security officers after being released from the ship’s brig, clutching a folded white sheet of permanent lifetime ban paperwork in her fist. Her face was flushed dark red in the morning Florida heat as she stormed up to the rear fender of our car.

Every muscle in Dad’s jaw tightened as he straightened up beside our open door and looked at her.

“If we were anywhere near Hampton Roads right now, Brenda, I would hand you twenty dollars for a bus fare and leave you standing on this curb,” Dad told her, his voice as cold and flat as steel. “The only reason I am unlocking this front door is because we are seven hundred miles from Virginia. Get in the front passenger seat, and don’t say a single word to the kids for the next twelve hours. The second this car pulls into our driveway in Virginia Beach, you are packing your bags and getting out of our house.”

Without waiting for her to reply, Dad closed our rear door securely, walked around to the driver’s side, and pulled out of Port Canaveral toward Interstate 95 North.

12:15 PM — Exit 94 Near Savannah, Georgia: The Gas Pump, The Restrooms, & Brenda’s First Angle

For the first three and a half hours heading north out of Florida across the Georgia state line, the inside of the car was dead silent except for the hum of the tires and the air conditioner. In the back seat, Katie and I sat pressed shoulder-to-shoulder with our inner hands laced together and Dad’s mylar-wrapped *Quantum Basic 5.0* library textbook resting across our knees.

Just past noon, the low-fuel chime dinged on the dashboard, and Dad signaled right at Exit 94 near Savannah, pulling under the canopy of a highway travel plaza so we could get gas and use the restrooms.

That stop was when the physical reality of leaving the ship hit Katie and me all over again.

On Thursday and Friday aboard the *Sunward Tropics*, we had rolled everywhere in the Medical Center's two folding loaner wheelchairs. Those wheelchairs belonged to the ship, which meant they were still back at Port Canaveral. When Dad opened our rear door beside Pump 6 and I swung my sneakers out onto the ninety-degree Georgia concrete, my knees and calves trembled so violently that I had to grab the roof frame with both hands just to keep from sliding onto the pavement. Beside me, when Katie tried to push herself up off the bench cushion, the strength in her right forearm gave out halfway up, and she gasped softly as she sank back against the seat.

Up front, Mom didn't even glance back at our door. She slammed the front passenger door shut and marched briskly across the concrete apron toward the air-conditioned travel store restrooms on her own.

Dad saw us struggling immediately. Leaving the gas nozzle clicking in the tank, he stepped right between Katie and me, braced his left arm firmly around Katie's waist and his right hand under my elbow, and took half of our weight onto his own shoulders.

"Take your time, kids—I've got both of you," Dad murmured close to our ears as he walked us slowly, step by shuffling step, across the hot pavement and up the curb ramp to the restroom hallway. He stood waiting right between the men's and women's doors until both of us came back out, then supported us all the way back to the back seat of the Holt before topping off the tank and paying at the window.

When Mom finally strolled back out of the convenience store carrying a bottle of water and climbed into the front passenger seat, her furious scowl from Port Canaveral was suddenly gone. As Dad shifted into drive and merged back onto I-95 North, I heard her voice change into the syrupy, reasonable tone she always used whenever she wanted to pretend nothing bad had happened.

"David, honey, look—let's be reasonable now that we're off that awful boat," Mom said, turning slightly toward him in the front seat. "Do you have any idea what I just went through for two and a half days? That purser had it out for me from the moment we boarded, and those security guards completely overreacted! They took my watch and my shoes, locked me in a windowless steel brig down on Deck 2 right over the engine room with a stainless-steel toilet and an overhead light that never turned off, fed me crew-galley mush on paper plates through a slot in the door, and had a medic and a guard peeking through a glass window at me every fifteen minutes while I had the worst headache of my life! I've been punished enough, David—there's no reason to talk crazy about me packing bags when we get home."

From the back bench seat, I watched Dad's knuckles turn white against the top of the steering wheel. In the rearview mirror, I saw his eyes flick briefly to Katie and me to make sure we were alright before he spoke without looking over at Mom.

“You swung a fist at a ship security officer because they wouldn’t serve you beer at four o’clock in the afternoon, Brenda,” Dad said in a low, gravelly voice that carried clearly to the back seat. “And while you were passed out drunk on the kids’ sofa bed, I had to hold our sixteen-year-old son and daughter up by their elbows because their legs and arms were giving out on them. Just five minutes ago at that gas pump, neither one of them could stand up out of the back seat without leaning on me, and you walked right past them without looking back. That wasn’t ‘vacation.’ That was who you are.”

4:45 PM — Rocky Mount, North Carolina: Drive-Thru Dinner & Cementing the Lawyer Decision

By quarter to five that afternoon, as the green highway signs ticked past Fayetteville and into Rocky Mount, North Carolina, the three of us were starving and needed another restroom stop.

After Dad helped Katie and me carefully in and out of the roadside rest-area bathrooms just off the exit—where my wrists shook so badly I could barely push the heavy metal restroom door open by myself—Dad didn’t make us walk inside a crowded highway sit-down restaurant and try to carry plastic food trays on trembling arms. Instead, he pulled the Holt sedan straight into the drive-thru lane of a *Penny’s* hamburger restaurant next to the interstate ramp, ordered four cheeseburger meals, and parked in the quietest, shadiest corner of the lot beneath a row of tall loblolly pines.

Turning around in the driver’s seat with a warm, protective look in his eyes, Dad handed a hot white paper bag of cheeseburgers and fries and two cold fountain colas—with the straws already popped through the plastic lids for us—back to Katie and me so we could eat comfortably right there on the bench seat with the *Quantum Basic 5.0* book propped between our knees.

Up in the front passenger seat, as Mom unwrapped her burger, I heard her abandon the sweet talk and try a completely different angle—cold financial bargaining.

“Think about this logically for two seconds, David,” Mom said, her voice sharp and calculating in the quiet car. “You’re taking classes at CCHR. How exactly do you think you’re going to pay the house note in Virginia Beach, buy groceries, finish your degree, and take care of two sixteen-year-olds all by yourself without my income? Look—I’ll cut back to drinking only on Friday and Saturday nights. We can put this behind us and go back to normal on Monday.”

Beside me on the back seat, Katie stopped chewing a fry and squeezed my right hand so hard her knuckles turned pale. Both of us held our breath, staring at the back of Dad’s headrest.

Instead of softening Dad, Mom’s attempt to bargain with him did the exact opposite.

I watched Dad slowly set his soda cup into the center console holder, turn his head squarely toward the passenger seat, and speak in a calm, ironclad voice I had never heard from him in my life.

“Thank you for saying that out loud, Brenda—because if I had one percent of doubt left about seeking a lawyer’s advice when we get home, you just erased it,” Dad told her evenly. “You still think this is about ‘one bad week,’ and you haven’t asked

Nathaniel or Katie a single time in eight hours why their legs and arms are failing them. I don't care if I have to work double shifts around my CCHR classes to pay the bills. First thing Monday morning at eight-thirty, I am calling a divorce lawyer to file for divorce and full custody of the twins, and my very next call is going to be to Dr. Chen's office to get both of them examined. We are never going back to 'normal.'"

Mom opened her mouth, saw the look on Dad's face, and snapped her jaw shut without another word for the rest of North Carolina and Virginia.

9:15 PM — Home in Virginia Beach: Packing the Bags

At nine-fifteen that night, after more than twelve hours on the road, the headlights of our Holt sedan finally swept across our driveway in Virginia Beach.

Before touching a single suitcase in the trunk, Dad walked around to our rear door, helped Katie and me out of the back seat, and supported both of us up the front steps and straight inside to the living room sofa, propping two throw pillows behind our backs and setting his *Quantum Basic 5.0* library book on the coffee table within easy reach.

Then, true to his word from Port Canaveral, Dad walked back out into the front foyer, folded his arms across his chest, and stood watch at the bottom of the stairs for forty-five straight minutes while Brenda packed her suitcases, dragged them out the front door to her car, and backed out of the driveway.

When Dad clicked the front deadbolt shut and walked into the living room to check on us, our house was finally, mercifully peaceful.

Part 5: Part 5: Monday Morning in Virginia Beach — The Divorce Lawyer, The PCP, & Borrowed Time

Date: 2001-08-27 at 10:15 America/New_York

Monday, August 27, 2001, 10:15 AM — The Divorce Lawyer, The PCP, & Borrowed Time

"Squeeze my fingers as hard as you can, Nathaniel, and hold it for five seconds," Dr. Evelyn Chen instructed gently inside Exam Room 2 of her Virginia Beach family practice clinic on Monday morning.

Sitting side by side on the crinkly white paper of the padded exam table in our t-shirts and jeans, Katie and I kept our inner hands laced tightly together between our knees while I reached my left hand out to squeeze Dr. Chen's fingers.

Earlier that morning at eight-thirty, while Katie and I sat at the kitchen table eating cereal, we had listened as Dad stood by the kitchen wall phone and kept the first half of his highway vow—calling a family law and divorce attorney's office off Independence Boulevard to schedule an immediate intake appointment for divorce and full custody of the two of us. The moment he hung up with the lawyer's receptionist, Dad dialed Dr. Chen, our Primary Care Physician, and explained how

badly our arms and legs had been giving out on the cruise and at the Interstate 95 rest stops. Dr. Chen's nurse had told him to bring both of us straight in at ten o'clock.

For the first two seconds, my grip held around Dr. Chen's fingers—and then, no matter how hard I concentrated, the strength in my forearm and wrist drained away like water through a sieve. When Dr. Chen tested Katie's grip, her shoulder resistance, and the dorsiflexion in both of our ankles, the exact same drop-off happened.

Dr. Chen stepped back, slipped her reflex hammer into the pocket of her white coat, and looked gravely at Dad, who was standing protectively right beside us.

"David," Dr. Chen said quietly, "bringing them in immediately after you got back from Florida was the exact right call."

"They've had mild cerebral palsy since they were little," Dad said, his hand resting warmly on Katie's shoulder. "Brenda always ignored it and acted like they were two completely typical kids, so at first I assumed the ship's movement was just aggravating their balance. Why are both their arms and their legs getting worse at sixteen?"

"Because cerebral palsy does not degenerate over time," Dr. Chen answered clearly, looking from Dad to Katie and me with deep compassion. "Cerebral palsy is a static, non-progressive condition. When sixteen-year-old twins begin losing measurable motor strength in both their lower extremities and their upper extremities over the course of a single summer, something else is happening."

Beside me on the exam table, Katie squeezed my fingers with every ounce of strength left in her hand, and I squeezed right back.

"I'm ordering a full neuromuscular blood panel, nerve conduction studies, and a genetic workup this morning," Dr. Chen continued gently, picking up her chart clipboard. "Until those test results come back and tell us exactly what condition we are dealing with, I need all three of you to prepare yourselves for the reality of what I'm seeing in their muscle tone today. When it comes to walking, Nathaniel and Katie are on borrowed time. Eventually, neither of them is going to be able to walk."

The quiet exam room seemed to hold its breath around those words—*on borrowed time*.

Yet as I looked sideways at my twin sister, and felt Dad's steady, unwavering arm wrap around both of our shoulders at once, the fear didn't break us. Whatever the test results showed when they came back from the lab, Mom's screaming was gone, Daddy was standing right beside us, and Katie and I were going to face every single mile of it together.